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APPS



**Les Amis, the European
app helping women form
friendships, launches in
New York**



Making friends as an adult can be tough, especially after moving to a new city. Luckily, modern technology exists, and more people are turning to apps like Bumble For Friends, Flox, and Timeleft to form new friendships quickly.

One app called [Les Amis](#) aims to stand out by targeting women, transgender, and LGBTQ+ individuals, primarily in the mid-20s to early 40s age demographic.

Les Amis uses AI to pair users with similar interests and encourages them to join local events offered within the app, such as pottery classes, book clubs, wine tastings, and Pilates.

TIME CREDITS: LES AMIS

Anna Bilych (ex-PayPal) created the app in 2022 alongside her co-founder, Oleg Pashinin (ex-Google AI), after struggling to rebuild her social circle after relocating.

Now the European-founded app is currently rolling out to U.S. markets. It launched in New York earlier this month.

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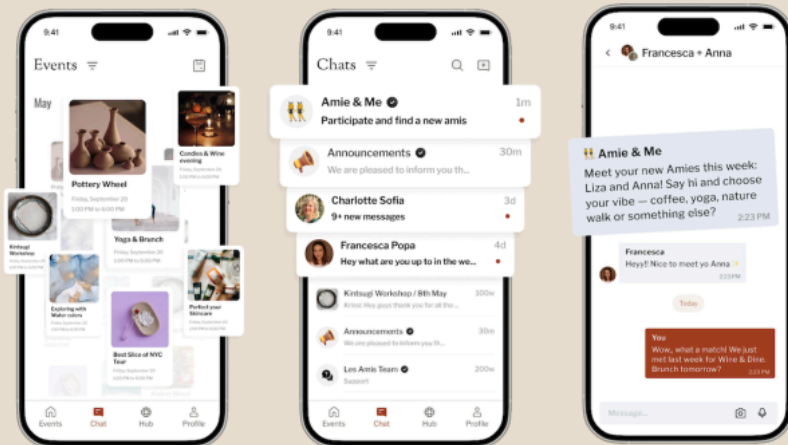
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IMAGE CREDITS: LES AMIS

Les Amis (French for “friends”) is designed to make it easy for users to connect with like-minded individuals in their area. It features a setup similar to dating apps, where users create profiles by selecting profile photos, writing a bio, and choosing from a list of interests, which include poetry, gardening, yoga, martial arts, and more.

The app includes an AI assistant named “Amis,” which aids in the matching process. Every two weeks, users can participate in matching rounds where the AI connects them with a potential friend based on shared interests. It also connects them to others in similar life stages — whether they’re single, married, a mother, new to town, or even looking to network with someone in a comparable career field.

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The AI determines matches on Mondays, giving users ample time to chat and coordinate meetups later in the week.

Additionally, the app features an explore page for users to sign up for local events and experiences, such as workshops, social gatherings, and recreational activities. It also recently launched “Trips,” where users can travel in groups to destinations like Morocco, Iceland, and the Amalfi Coast.

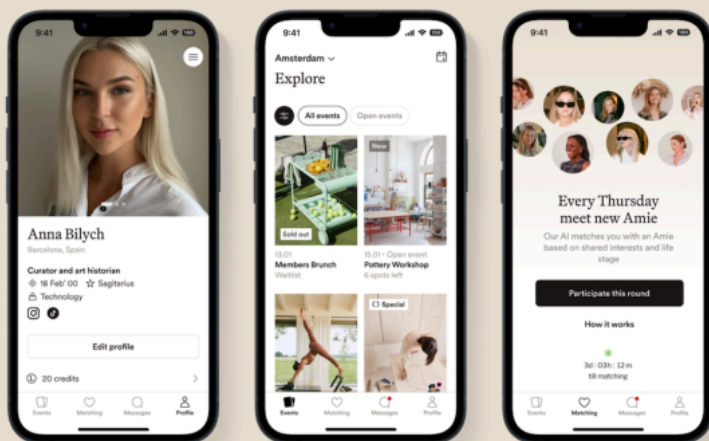


IMAGE CREDITS: LES AMIS

The app operates on a membership-based business model, with fees that vary by city. For example, the monthly fee is \$70 in New York and €55 in Amsterdam. The membership includes a flexible credit system to spend toward experiences, which can be spent in any city where Les Amis is available, enabling members to attend events while traveling.

Les Amis is available on [iOS](#) and [Android](#) devices across Europe, including Amsterdam, Barcelona, Berlin, Madrid, Milan, Munich, Paris, and Stockholm.

As for U.S. markets, the app was introduced in Austin last May, in addition to New York. Les Amis plans to expand to Boston next, followed by Washington, D.C., next month, and Miami in October. A launch in Los Angeles is also on the roadmap.

It's important to note that there are currently no Les Amis events happening in New York, but they will soon launch on August 25. The app is still in the application acceptance phase and has received over 2,000 applications from users in New York.

In total, the app touts about 120,000 installs, and around 30,000 women have attended events to date. The company also reports that it has recently reached an annual run rate of \$1 million.

Topics: [Apps](#) [female-led startups](#) [friends](#) [Startups](#)



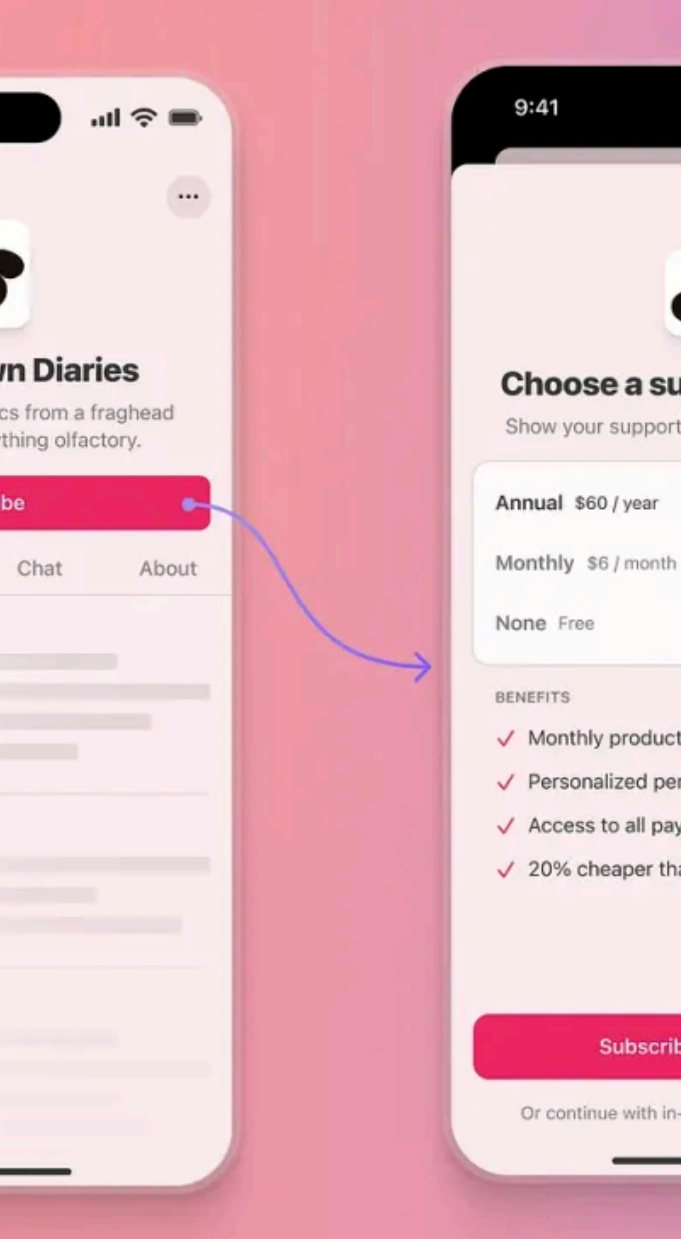
Lauren Forristal



Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch....

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Substack writers can now direct US readers to (often cheaper) web-based subscriptions on iOS

Sarah Perez — 10:16 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Newsletter subscription platform Substack will begin taking advantage of an option on the U.S. App Store that allows users to make purchases outside of Apple's in-app purchasing system. This functionality is permitted by a [change to the App Store's rules in May](#), as a result of [Epic Games' antitrust lawsuit](#) against the tech giant.

Since then, a number of top apps have moved to offer in-app purchase links that point to their own websites, including [Spotify](#), [Patreon](#), and the [Amazon Kindle](#) app, among others.

In Substack's case, support for external payments will benefit both the company, which no longer has to pay the App Store a commission on those web sales, and consumers, who will have access to reduced pricing. Meanwhile, Substack creators will

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be able to offer their readers the option of whether they want the convenience of Apple’s in-app payments system (IAP) or the web payment option, which is now accessible without having to leave the app.

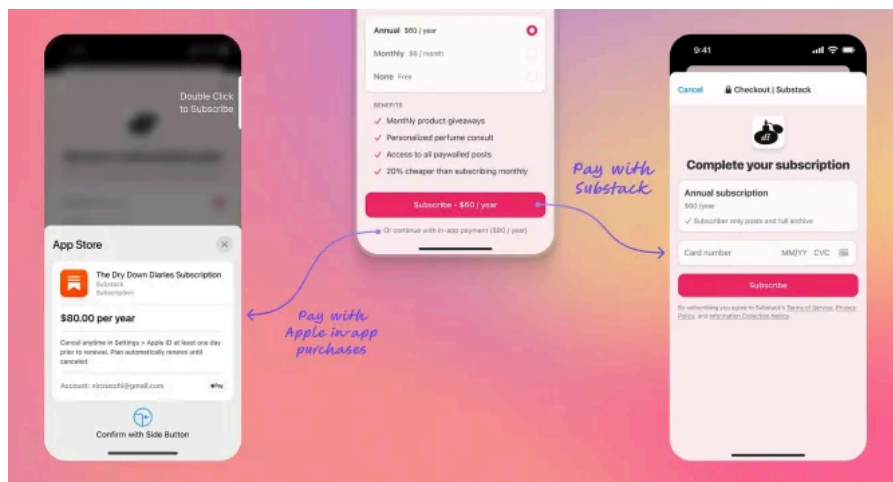


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

Substack explains it will automatically adjust its customers’ iOS app price higher to account for Apple’s fees, allowing creators to take home the same amount of money as a web subscription. However, Substack writers can disable this feature if they choose. (Substack will continue to take its own 10% fee based on the web subscription price, as before.)

The company said in its blog post that it’s also offering its writers “migration tools.” We originally reported that these could help migrate users from one payments platform to another, but Substack reached out to correct this. Instead, it said that the tools are meant to help creators access billing information for Apple-managed subscriptions if they ever leave the platform.

Currently, more than 30,000 publications on the platform have in-app purchases enabled; Substack says early tests of the expanded set of payment options have driven a boost in paid sign-ups. It did not, however, share specific numbers related to this.

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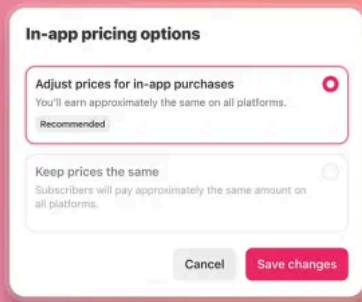


IMAGE CREDITS: SUBSTACK

The public launch of the external payments option will only impact new Substack subscriptions. Substack writers don't have to take any action unless they want to lower the prices for those using Apple's payments system.

Per Apple's App Store rules, fully opting out of offering IAP is not allowed.

While the changes impact the Substack app in the U.S., the company says it's still evaluating if it makes sense to switch to the more complex rules Apple offers in the EU and U.K. for developers who want to forgo IAP.

Updated after publication to correct and clarify how the migration tools work.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | X butterfly @ in

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

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X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

Sarah Perez — 1:49 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

Elon Musk's X is struggling on Android devices in terms of new installs, even while App Store

downloads grow, according to new data from app intelligence provider Appfigures. In July 2025, X downloads on Google Play saw a significant decline, as new installs dropped by 44% year-over-year worldwide, even as iOS downloads grew by 15%.

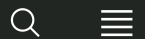
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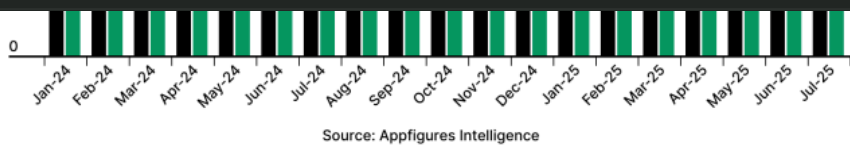


IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm didn't speculate on what's causing the decline on Android devices beyond suggesting that the X app on Android is known to be a sore spot for the company. Recently hired [X head of product Nikita Bier](#), known for growth hacking teen social apps like [Gas](#) and [TBH](#) (then [selling them](#)), has hinted that X is looking to address issues on Android, where its app is [notoriously buggy](#) and [often crashes](#).

In a post on the platform, Bier [announced](#) that X was hiring for its "Android Dream Team" to work on rebuilding the X Android app. He also recently posted that X's iOS app [had just seen a record week in terms of installs](#), perhaps hoping to draw attention away from the large Android slump.

New X Downloads on Mobile by Month with Year-Over-Year Growth

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play

Month	App Store	YoY	Google Play	YoY	Unified	YoY
Jan-24	2,963,000	-	6,303,000	-	9,266,000	-
Feb-24	3,623,000	-	6,352,000	-	9,975,000	-
Mar-24	3,363,000	-	6,689,000	-	10,052,000	-
Apr-24	2,971,000	-	7,536,000	-	10,507,000	-
May-24	2,993,000	-	7,676,000	-	10,669,000	-
Jun-24	3,514,000	-	8,787,000	-	12,301,000	-
Jul-24	3,429,000	-	7,742,000	-	11,171,000	-
Aug-24	3,338,000	-	7,953,000	-	11,291,000	-
Sep-24	2,679,000	-	6,347,000	-	9,026,000	-
Oct-24	2,876,000	-	5,895,000	-	8,771,000	-
Nov-24	2,629,000	-	5,735,000	-	8,364,000	-
Dec-24	2,691,000	-	5,861,000	-	8,552,000	-
Jan-25	3,312,000	12%	6,019,000	-5%	9,331,000	1%
Feb-25	3,475,000	-4%	5,535,000	-13%	9,010,000	-10%
Mar-25	3,359,000	0%	6,814,000	2%	10,173,000	1%
Apr-25	3,029,000	2%	5,032,000	-33%	8,061,000	-23%
May-25	3,370,000	13%	4,766,000	-38%	8,136,000	-24%
Jun-25	3,531,000	0%	4,451,000	-49%	7,982,000	-35%
Jul-25	3,950,000	15%	4,334,000	-44%	8,284,000	-26%

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also

likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [butterfly](#) [m](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Hank Green's Focus Friend app is climbing the App Store charts — and it's extremely cute

Amanda Silberling — 10:36 AM PDT · August 18, 2025



You must stay focused. You cannot open TikTok, or Instagram, or whatever little phone games you like to play. If you fail, you will make an anthropomorphic bean very sad, because its knitting project depends on your ability to stay focused.

IMAGE CREDITS: FOCUS FRIEND

This is the premise of [Focus Friend](#), a productivity app created by [Honey B Games](#) and [Hank Green](#), the longtime online creator/entrepreneur/educator/[sock salesman](#). Though the app was soft launched last month, Focus Friend is only now gaining momentum on the App Store charts — likely because Green and his brother, author John Green, are [posting about it more](#) — reaching No. 4 among all free apps and No. 2 among productivity apps.

[@hankgreen1](#)

Your Deserve a Focus Friend

[🎵 original sound – Hank Green](#)

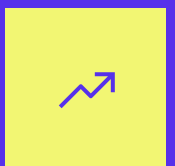
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Focus Friend, which is available on [iOS](#) and [Android](#), has the bones of a typical productivity app. It invites you to set a timer on your phone, which will temporarily prevent you from opening certain apps (on iOS, the “Deep Focus Mode” setting connects to your own screen time settings, where you can designate which apps to block).

But what makes Focus Friend different is that it assigns you a new friend — a little bean — which you can give a cute name, like Garbanzo, or Susan Bean Anthony, or Eda (it’s short for Edamame).

Your bean needs help focusing on its knitting. And it can only focus if you refrain from opening the apps that distract you from your work. If you successfully complete your focus session, your bean will give you in-game points (socks), which you can use to buy decorations for its room — because the only thing more motivating than helping a bean knit is to buy it a cute poster for its wall.

Focus Friend has a lot in common with [Finch](#), a popular self-care app that incentivizes users to maintain healthy habits by giving them a virtual bird companion. Your bird grows when you complete certain tasks that you set for yourself, like drinking water, brushing your teeth, or cleaning your room. Like the Tamagotchis of yore, these apps exploit our desire to protect a cute bundle of pixels by doing stuff that’s good for us.

Focus Friend is functional as a free app, but you can pay to give your bean different skins — you can make your bean look like a cat (a “Kitt-ney Bean”) or a jelly bean, for example. There’s also a subscription that allows your bean to knit scarves, which can be exchanged for premium decorations. Green [posted](#) on Bluesky that Focus Friend is “very much trying to be an ad-free experience because the mobile ad ecosystem kinda blows.” But the app still has to

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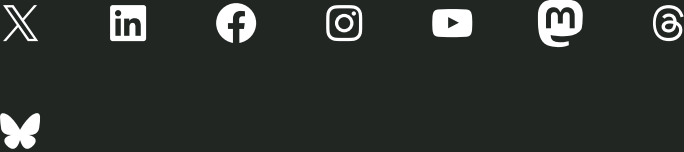
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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also...

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